

How You Speak and Write: How to Speak So That People Want to
Listen : Julian Treasure : TED

Various speakers

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Chapter 1

How to Speak So That People Want to Listen

This lecture is short, but it is built with unusual precision. Treasure begins by enlarging the stakes: the human voice is the instrument we all play, perhaps the most powerful sound in the world. He then narrows that grandeur into a practical puzzle. If the medium is so strong, why is it so common to speak and not be heard? The answer unfolds in a deliberate sequence: first a diagnosis of the habits that destroy listenability, then a positive ethical foundation, then a toolbox of vocal variables, then a warm-up routine, and finally a wider vision of what a world of conscious sound might look like.

1.1 The Voice and the Problem

The opening claim is deliberately large. The voice can start a war; it can say “I love you.” Treasure wants us to feel, before anything else, that speech is not decorative. It is consequential. Only after that amplification does he pose the governing question of the talk: why do people so often fail to listen, and how can speech be made powerful enough to change the world?

In a compact editorial shorthand, we may summarize the paradox this way:

$$\text{powerful medium} \not\Rightarrow \text{effective communication.} \quad (1.1)$$

The voice has enormous potential, but potential alone does not guarantee reception.

Treasure’s next move is crucial. He does not begin with a trick for sounding better. He begins by asking what blocks listening in the first place. The lecture therefore proceeds by diagnosis before prescription.

1.1.1 Question & Answer

Question. Why do people fail to listen when we speak?

Answer. Treasure’s answer has two layers. First, there are recurrent habits that make us hard to listen to before technique even enters the picture. Second, even when our intentions are good,

delivery matters: the same words can arrive with different force, authority, and meaning depending on how they are spoken. The lecture therefore moves from habits, to foundations, to vocal mechanics.

1.2 The Seven Deadly Sins of Speaking

Treasure's first answer is entirely negative. He assembles a list of "seven deadly sins of speaking," not as a complete moral system, but as a practical classification of habits that corrode listenability. Their order is part of the lecture's rhythm, so it is worth preserving it explicitly:

$$S_7 = (\text{gossip, judging, negativity, complaining, excuses, embroidery, dogmatism}). \quad (1.2)$$

Remark 1.1. This notation is editorial. It is meant only to preserve the lecture's ordered repertoire on the page.

We may now follow the list as the talk does.

1. **Gossip.** Speaking ill of someone who is not present immediately weakens trust. If a speaker gossips about others, we naturally infer that the same speaker will gossip about us later.
2. **Judging.** It is hard to listen to someone while feeling simultaneously judged and found wanting. A judging speaker forces the listener into self-defense.
3. **Negativity.** Treasure illustrates this with the line about October 1 being dreadful. The point is not merely comic. Persistent negativity contracts the listener's world and makes speech heavy.
4. **Complaining.** Introduced as another form of negativity, complaining is allowed to stand on its own because it is so familiar. Treasure calls it viral misery: it spreads unhappiness rather than light.
5. **Excuses.** Here the type is the blame-thrower, the person who passes responsibility on to everyone else. Such speech feels evasive because it never lets accountability come to rest.
6. **Embroidery.** By embroidery he means exaggeration. Language loses calibration. If everything is called awesome, then language can no longer register genuine awe. And exaggeration, pushed far enough, becomes lying.
7. **Dogmatism.** Dogmatism is the confusion of facts with opinions. Once those are conflated, the listener is no longer being invited into thought, but battered by assertion treated as truth.

The important thing here is cumulative structure. Treasure is not simply telling us to be nicer. He is showing, one habit at a time, how the channel from speaker to listener is damaged. By the end of the list the diagnosis is sharp: often people do not listen because we ourselves have made listening difficult.

That is why the lecture now needs a genuine pivot. After diagnosis, it asks for foundation.

1.3 HAIL: The Positive Foundations

Treasure now asks the question that the previous section has prepared: is there a positive way to think about this? Yes. The answer is another ordered structure, compressed into the mnemonic

HAIL:

$$H \mapsto \text{honesty}, \quad (1.3)$$

$$A \mapsto \text{authenticity}, \quad (1.4)$$

$$I \mapsto \text{integrity}, \quad (1.5)$$

$$L \mapsto \text{love}. \quad (1.6)$$

The word matters in two senses. It is memorable, and it also carries the sense of greeting or acclaiming enthusiastically. The suggestion is that words spoken from these four foundations will be received that way.

1.3.1 Question & Answer

Question. What positive foundation replaces the seven sins?

Answer. Treasure's answer is that powerful speech must be truthful, real, dependable, and benevolent. Honesty keeps the line straight. Authenticity means we are not speaking through a mask. Integrity means we are our word. Love means wishing the listener well. These are not ornaments added after technique; they are the ground on which technique can stand.

The most interesting local tension in this block appears in the relation between honesty and love. Treasure does not recommend "absolute honesty" as though that were sufficient. He immediately supplies the counterexample of unnecessary bluntness. In a compact form:

$$\text{absolute honesty} \not\Rightarrow \text{good speech}, \quad \text{honesty tempered with love} \Rightarrow \text{good speech}. \quad (1.7)$$

Love does not cancel truthfulness; it constrains its use.

He then adds a second, softer claim:

$$\text{love} \Rightarrow \text{reduced tendency to judge}. \quad (1.8)$$

This is not a theorem, and it should not be read as one. It is a qualitative incompatibility. If we are genuinely wishing somebody well, the stance of judging them becomes more difficult to hold.

Treasure ends this block with a decisive transition: that is what we say. It remains to ask how we say it.

1.4 The Vocal Toolbox

At this point the lecture turns from ethical foundations to vocal mechanics. The voice becomes, in Treasure's phrase, an amazing toolbox that most people have never opened. For note-writing purposes it is useful to collect the tools into one object:

$$V_{\text{tool}} = (\text{register, timbre, prosody, pace, silence, pitch, volume}). \quad (1.9)$$

The point is not that Treasure writes such a formula. He does not. The point is that the lecture itself is now operating as if speech were a controllable system with a small set of principal variables.

Register. Treasure first contrasts where the voice is placed: high in the nose, more centrally in the throat, and lower in the chest. He is not offering a formal acoustics lesson, but a practical phenomenology of speaking. If we want weight, he says, we tend to go down. That leads directly to his rhetorical empirical claim:

$$\text{lower register} \Rightarrow \text{greater perceived power and authority.} \quad (1.10)$$

This is why he says that we vote for politicians with lower voices. The point is not numerical measurement; it is perceived force.

Timbre. Timbre is the way the voice feels. Treasure describes the preferred voice as rich, smooth, and warm, “like hot chocolate.” The technical point hidden inside the metaphor is important: timbre is trainable. Breathing, posture, and exercise can change it.

Prosody. Prosody is, for Treasure, route one for meaning in conversation. It is the sing-song meta-language by which speech acquires force and direction. This is why monotone delivery is hard to hear: it removes one of the principal carriers of meaning.

1.4.1 Question & Answer

Question. Why can the same words mean different things when spoken differently?

Answer. Because meaning does not live in the lexical string alone. Treasure’s examples of repetitive question-ending intonation and of the line “Where did you leave my keys?” show that contour changes the speech act even when the words are fixed.

We may write that idea in a minimal formal way. Let

$$u = \text{“Where did you leave my keys”}, \quad (1.11)$$

$$m_1 = \mathcal{M}(u, \pi_1), \quad (1.12)$$

$$m_2 = \mathcal{M}(u, \pi_2), \quad (1.13)$$

where π_1 and π_2 are different prosodic or pitch contours and $\mathcal{M}$ is the meaning perceived by the listener. Then Treasure’s point is simply

$$m_1 \neq m_2. \quad (1.14)$$

Remark 1.2. Again, this is editorial notation. It captures the logic of the demonstration: identical words, different contour, different meaning.

This is exactly why repetitive question-ending prosody is a problem. When every sentence rises as though it were a question, statements lose their declarative force. One contour cannot carry the full range of intended meanings.

Pace and silence. Treasure then demonstrates pace by contrast. One can speak very quickly to produce excitement, or slow right down to create emphasis. At the end of that scale lies silence. Silence is not a failure to keep talking; it is a communicative instrument:

$$\text{fast pace} \Rightarrow \text{excitement}, \quad \text{slow pace} \Rightarrow \text{emphasis}, \quad \text{silence} \Rightarrow \text{powerful pause.} \quad (1.15)$$

This is why a talk need not be filled with “ums” and “ahs.” Silence can carry weight.

Pitch. Pitch often works together with pace to indicate arousal, but Treasure shows that it can also act on its own. The paired deliveries of the same sentence differ because the melodic contour differs. The words are held fixed; the intention is altered.

Volume. The last tool is volume. Loudness can generate command and excitement. Quietness can make a room lean in. Treasure’s warning is against constant broadcasting, which he names “sodcasting”: the careless imposition of sound on other people.

The section as a whole performs a real technical shift. We are no longer merely told to “speak well.” We are shown a set of variables that can be varied deliberately, each one changing how the listener receives the utterance.

1.5 Preparing the Instrument

The next pivot is motivational. Treasure asks us to think of the moments when speaking really matters: a public talk, a proposal, a request for a raise, a wedding speech. In such moments, he says, we owe it to ourselves to prepare. The metaphor now sharpens once more: the voice is not only a toolbox, but an engine, and no engine works well without being warmed up.

1.5.1 Question & Answer

Question. Why warm up the voice before speaking?

Answer. Because important speech deserves instrument care. If the voice is the engine that will carry the act of communication, then one should not start cold. Treasure does not leave this at the level of metaphor. He turns it into a concrete pre-performance protocol.

For compact reference we may write

$$W_6 = (\text{breath and sigh, lip percussion, lip trill, tongue } la\text{-work, rolled } r, \text{ siren } (we \rightarrow or)), \quad (1.16)$$

but the real content lies in the ordered routine:

1. Raise the arms, breathe deeply in, and sigh out.
2. Warm up the lips with repeated “bop” sounds.
3. Continue with the lip trill, like the buzzing sound a child makes.
4. Wake up the tongue with exaggerated “la, la, la” articulation.
5. Roll an *r*, which Treasure memorably calls “champagne for the tongue.”
6. Finish with the siren, moving from high “we” down to low “or.”

The routine matters because it is the lecture’s first fully practical payoff. Treasure has moved from vice, to foundation, to variables, and now to protocol. The audience is not only told what matters; it is asked to rehearse it.

He then gives a short imperative coda to the whole block: next time you speak, do those in advance. That line should remain visible in the notes, because it marks the conversion of exposition into habit.

1.6 Closing Vision: Conscious Speaking, Conscious Listening, Conscious Sound

At the close Treasure says that he wants to put the whole discussion in context. The move is characteristic: after a sequence of compact repertoires and local demonstrations, he widens the frame and asks what sort of world these practices would build.

His diagnosis of the present state may be written compactly as

$$\text{current world} = (\text{poor speaking, poor listening, noise, bad acoustics}). \quad (1.17)$$

This is not only an individual deficiency. It is an environmental one. People speak badly; listeners do not listen; the acoustic setting itself works against understanding.

The counterfactual world he wants us to imagine is the opposite:

$$\text{desired world} = (\text{powerful speaking, conscious listening, conscious sound creation, fit-for-purpose acoustics}). \quad (1.18)$$

The lecture does not end, then, with a private self-improvement lesson. It ends with a civic acoustics. What would happen if we created sound consciously, consumed sound consciously, and designed our environments consciously for sound? Treasure's answer is that such a world would sound beautiful, and that understanding would become the norm.

That final widening is essential to the talk's rhythm. What began as a question about why people do not listen ends as a question about what sort of human world we are building with our habits of speech and listening.

1.7 Summary

Treasure's lecture is built from a series of nested structures, each motivated by the last. We begin with the paradox of a powerful voice that often fails. We then diagnose the failure through the seven sins. We rebuild the moral ground through HAIL. We open the vocal toolbox and see that delivery is not accidental but variable. We prepare that instrument through the six warm-ups. And we end by widening the whole inquiry into a world of conscious sound.

The chapter should therefore be read not as a bag of speaking tips, but as a small structured theory of communication. Speech matters because it is powerful. It fails for identifiable reasons. It can be rebuilt on explicit foundations. Its force depends on controllable variables. And when we learn to use those variables deliberately, the gain is not only rhetorical effectiveness, but a larger possibility of understanding.